

'A Guiding Light in a Virtual Haven': A Preliminary Analysis of Conversations Around Navigating and Repairing Self-worth in an Online Professional Community for Women

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ABSTRACT

The establishment of one's professional identity can be essential to one's sense of worth. For women, such challenges can be further magnified owing to the need to perform traditional roles along with sustaining a professional career. Through an analysis of a random sample of 10 discussion threads (80 conversation traces) from a subreddit called r/careerwomen, we explore the needs that draw women to use such forums and the ways in which such forums help develop endurance. Our preliminary analysis provides 2 main themes towards understanding how multiple socio-cultural pressures create tensions in defining one's sense of worth. In contrast, 5 other themes provide insights into strategies to redefine norms of worth. Building on these themes, we propose the analytical frame of *morale repair*, which aims to discuss how such socio-technical interventions can be designed and structured to further address the struggles for women in establishing a sense of worth.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in collaborative and social computing.**

KEYWORDS

Self-worth, Gendered Identity, Cultural norms, Reddit, Thematic content analysis

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1 INTRODUCTION

Marginalization is the process where members of society are pushed to the periphery and denied a place within it [43], and people are usually marginalized based on myriad identity intersections such

as race, gender, class, and sexual orientation [5]. Here, we define self-identity as a person's self-concept: how they see themselves physically and socially [1]. In this view, self-identity is the self that a person can refer to and that others see them as. Importantly, a strong sense of self-identity can give a person security in their daily life [15]. However, marginalized groups experience barriers in living their lives, being themselves, and in seeing themselves at par with others. Such experiences represent how marginalization becomes institutionalized and normalized in societal structures and everyday social systems [26]. In this way, marginalized groups experience insecurity by virtue of being themselves or being unable to be themselves.

Today, a broad range of Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) allow marginalized groups to be themselves or see themselves represented in others [7, 11]. Scholarship in CSCW and CHI has found that online community spaces provide opportunities for people to negotiate and think about their identities [6, 7, 12]. Conversely, other scholars have highlighted how people with marginalized identities continue to experience harassment [28], exclusion [35, 45], and other forms of harm through their engagements in online spaces [20, 30].

To further explore the relationship between marginalization and sociotechnical systems, we focus our attention on the intersection between gender and professional identities. The notion of a career or professional identity gained significance in the nineteenth century, which witnessed mass reform in profession, government service and educational institutions [16]. However, such careers often became key traits to define masculinity and men were seen as the central figures of authority and financial security in both the family and in society [16]. As a product of such chauvinistic ideologies, women experienced several social exclusions and bounds on freedom in professional exploration [19]. However through countless movements for emancipation, the twentieth century saw a change in this dynamic [33]. But, in several cultures, pursuit of a professional goal for women is still seen as a conflict with the traditional role of the mother and a caregiver causing stress and tension [21]. Such tensions are further exacerbated by the additional burden to adhere to the expectations and standards of appearance and demeanor that are thrust onto women in order for their professional footprint to be perceived as acceptable [14, 17]. In this way, women can experience chronic insecurity in their everyday lives as mediated by the tensions between how they see themselves and how society tells them they should see themselves. This leads to the question of **how women are using sociotechnical systems to navigate these tensions and seek opportunities for redefining such norms?**

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In this paper, we explore the ways in which women are working to address these tensions. Specifically, we develop an analytic frame that brings together concepts of gendered identity and self-worth to highlight how women are drawing on sociotechnical systems to navigate the norms of gender and professional identity, and attempt to collectively re-define their own worth. Specifically, in this study we explore how women seek to address and redress challenges they face in defining their sense of worth in relation to their professional identities. To accomplish this aim, we explore a set of conversation traces from the subreddit, r/careerwomen, that revolves around issues pertaining to professional growth for women. We particularly chose to study Reddit as literature suggests that as a platform it offers a safe space for discussion and deliberation on a wide variety of topics [39, 46]. Akin to the context of exploration of this study, the subreddit r/careerwomen serves as a channel for discussing issues surrounding challenges, uncertainty around career management and balancing work/personal life. The central research questions we seek to address in this preliminary analysis are:

- *How are women leveraging online discussion groups to discuss challenges in navigating their sense of self-worth?*
- *How might such online groups in turn help to address challenges that women face in navigating their self-worth?*

2 LITERATURE REVIEW: THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN IDENTITY AND SELF-WORTH

In our work, we draw explicitly on Judith Butler [3, 37], who argues how identities, such as gender, are not fixed. Rather, the social spaces in which people are embedded are often gendered and produce gendered performances. That is, gender is constructed and re-constructed, practiced and performed across social settings. In this view, people who identify as women are not born as women; they come to learn how to practice and perform as women. Thus, gender is a learned situated performance, and these performances are often mediated by institutional and cultural logics across social environments, such as the work place.

Performing in accordance with one's gendered expectations can be explicitly tied to one's feelings of self-worth. Self worth—a person's internal perception of their own value or whether they deserve love from others—is socially constructed and closely tied with feelings of acceptance and approval depending upon a set of cultural values and perspectives [24, 25]. Further, socio-cultural norms may construe the markers of professional success, which in turn may affect our sense of worth [2, 24]. In this regard, cultural constructs such as family, gender and sociopolitical status have been shown to affect the sense of worth in relation to career pursuit and success [10, 22, 31].

Yet, despite the logics that often mediate how people enact, perform, and maintain their identities, these performances can come in conflict with how individuals see themselves or want others to see them. Thus, having a platform or channel to share strategies in navigating struggles in determining worth becomes essential. This motivates the need to understand the relation between the use of online communities and self-worth [36].

Prior work in this context, highlights how self-worth affects what, where and how people present themselves and share information [23, 32, 42]. These prior studies have spoken about the challenges of women in establishing their sense of worth [29], challenges in managing their professional identity [13] and their use of technology to build community and foster a sense of solidarity [41], a holistic view of how these different streams of literature may actually intersect is yet to be fully explored. Further, a closer inspection into how such online communities mediate conversations about how cultural constraints and inhibitions impact the sense of worth or how such channels can help repair one's sense of worth, especially in the context of professional identity development is yet to be fully explored. Thus, expanding and extending the prior realms of work, the aim of this exploration is to understand how online channels of communication may help create opportunities for women to navigate their sense of worth as they negotiate multiple facets of their social and professional identities.

3 METHOD

Data for this study was collected using the python wrapper to access the Pushshift.io database (PSAW), which has become a popular source of collecting Reddit data [47]. First, all the posts (question, answer threads) created for the r/careerwomen subreddit were extracted. A total of 979 such posts (not including associated comments) were compiled. For this analysis, a random sample of 10 posts (80 conversation traces in total) was analyzed. Rooted in grounded theory, a thematic coding approach was used to draw preliminary insights from the data sample [4].

4 INSIGHTS TOWARDS EMERGENT THEMES

From the initial exploration of the data, we find two major characteristics of the conversations: (i) Challenges in establishing self-worth (2) strategies to re-define self-worth. The following paragraphs describe these further in more detail.

4.1 Challenges in establishing self-worth

These were mostly centered on narratives of struggle, trials and tribulations as one attempts to balance multiple roles and manage social pressure. These tensions in often cases were aggravated by the pressure to balance collectivist and individualist values [27]. We illustrate this through the following two themes.

- (1) **Challenges in navigating gendered social norms:** These posts often depict uncertainty, lack of faith in one-self and were often accompanied by tensions in navigating familial relationships in relation to pursuing one's career. Some of these posts also hint at possible inter-generational tension, which further creates stress and questions about oneself. It depicts the struggle of prioritizing one's own goals and aspirations, while also fulfilling all societal expectations. An example excerpt was: *"I am stressed to a crisp now. I know that working 60 hours a week (I would need the permission of my husband to work any less), I cannot handle all this-body of a model, super woman at home, single-handedly doing it w/o the help of a SO. Professional women out there who have had a career + family, I'd love to hear your thoughts. How did you do it all?"*

- (2) **Reflections of worth as a product of professionalization:** These posts depict the uncertainty that people face when they transition to new roles or may want more inputs from others in deciding the best course of action. Also, evident in the examples as presented below is a sense of dissatisfaction and a desire to search for the right career alignment. Often such tensions intersect with social issues which may affect the economy (such as COVID-19 pandemic) or may be ways for people to connect and create strong bonds with others who are going through similar travails within the community. Example excerpt: *"I recently lost my job in November and went on unemployment due to COVID. I just received a job offer at a place I really don't want to work. I am not sure if I should take it or remain unemployed and look for a job I really want. I really need advice"*. Further, embedded in these posts, often people vent about potential hostility in their present workplace, moral misalignment and resistance to masculine toxicity which impacts the choice of career they wish to pursue [14]. Example excerpt: *"Struggling to love my job. I love my career and the nature of it but feeling like I'm being in a toxic environment for me (I am the only female). The culture there encourages aggressiveness and competition which I don't want to be."*

4.2 Strategies for re-defining worth

These conversations mainly act as narratives to help heal and repair one's sense of self. These were aimed at building endurance by engaging as a community to help struggling individuals [8, 18]. We illustrate this through the following five themes.

- (1) **Redefining Norms of Worth: Questioning Pre-Existing Cultural Prescriptions:** A theme in the comments was to create a sense to empower others. These were typically aimed at fostering a sense of self-esteem. Often these comments were imbued with a sense of validation and empathy, pledging support and encouragement. Further, these were aimed at broadening the perspective of others by providing thoughts to widen the views presented by the original poster. Infused in these conversations, were also attempts to question pre-existing cultural notions, especially in those cases where the original poster depicted moral conflicts that arose due to cultural stereotypes. These themes in most cases arise as a response to the theme of challenges induced by gendered social norms. Example excerpt: *"I think the idea of doing it all is overwhelming and puts so much pressure on women. No one is ever asking how men are doing it all working and being good fathers."*
- (2) **Collective healing: Sharing personal stories:** These posts were aimed at uplifting the morale of others by sharing similar life circumstances and lessons learned from such experiences. This category depicts how people want to foster a sense of community and camaraderie among all members. It highlights expressions of solidarity and the desire to assure others that they are not alone. Example excerpt: *"I have been a full-time medical professional for 13 years, and for the last 5 years I have worked 50-60 hours a week running my own practice. Sure, I can set my own hours, but the work still has*

to be done, regardless of other demands on my time. I also have a family to take care of and a household to run, meals to prepare, and my own health and fitness to maintain. It's a lot for anyone to manage for any length of time, and if you are going to handle it all successfully, you need to be forgiving of yourself, and maintain realistic standards and expectations for every component of your busy life."

- (3) **Spiritual guidance:** These conversations offer spiritual mechanism to help repair sense of worth and restore self-belief. They attempt to inspire others to accept and nurture their inner selves and not feel they necessarily need to perform according to the standards of the world [9]. Example excerpt: *"You are who you are. There is no relevant value judgment. You are a high energy person with the ability to focus your energy positively. Where's the problem? In any relationship, both must bend; neither have to break. It's hard to be content until you have a few goals achieved behind you."*
- (4) **Strategies for enhancing professional outcomes by resisting toxic work regimes:** These conversations provided advice and guidance on resisting, recovering and navigating toxic work regimes and culture. Often these conversations involved insights to gauge such challenging circumstances more holistically or by advising others to hone their voice and right to express themselves. Example excerpt: *"11 hour days are brutal!!! That's how I spent a lot of my 20s, so I feel you. Do you have anything you can do to break up the day and get a brain break? Some fresh air, stretch your legs out? That helps me to take little breaks. Even when they are short it can really help to clear your mind and boost your energy."*
- (5) **Embracing collective wisdom:** A set of posts depicted appreciation and acknowledgement of support. It shows how in the process of finding one's self worth, connecting with the community is essential and helps in the process of healing. Example excerpt: *"This is so supportive. Really, really, really, what I needed to hear. I am very passionate about medicine, and I know I also want to be that woman who has kids and spends time with them, but I also know I can't "do it all" to the perfection that my mom did. So glad to hear that this does not make me a bad person."*

5 DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Through the above analysis we can see ways in which such online communities can be essential outlets to share and disclose challenges and seek assistance, as women straddle multiple facets of their identity and attempt to define their sense of worth. These themes provide insights into the ways in which these online channels provide occasions for repair and remedy for situations wherein one feels alienated from social customs and norms and can help establish long term coping mechanisms [44]. So, how such socio-technical infrastructure in the form of online channels can serve to repair one's sense of worth through sharing, caring and by crafting a safe space to discuss such challenges is the main theme that this work aims to ultimately address [38, 46].

More importantly, such platforms can act as tools for *morale repair*, which we define as, the technology mediated process of

community building for healing and recovery, through which people, particularly women, can develop a sense of worth and confidence as they face constant struggles in the process of exploring and defining their professional identity. To situate this analytical frame, we will explore the multiple, interdependent socio-technical aspects associated with such online discussion forums, a precursor to which is this initial exploration of conversational themes. Such an analysis can help inform the practices of platform governance and moderation work and also provide insights towards the way affordances of such channels can be designed [40].

6 FUTURE WORK

Future work in this regard will aim to holistically understand the conversational traces to infer ways in which people create and nurture occasions of morale repair. Further, through complimenting qualitative investigations and design studies, the goal will be to understand factors that motivate participation and engagement in such channels and ways in which such channels act or can act as tools to support *morale repair*. Pertinent ethical considerations have been kept in mind for this study, and appropriate ethical protocols will be complied with for subsequent analysis on this topic [34].

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